



MENTAL MODELS · 02

The Abstraction Ladder

Choosing the right altitude for the decision in front of you.



“How does AI work?” is really three different questions — depending on how far down the ladder you go.



Top rung: it predicts the next word.
True, but useless for reasoning about it.



Middle rung: a neural network weighing probabilities over patterns in text. Useful for most day-to-day decisions.



Bottom rung: attention mechanisms, transformers, gradient descent. Useful if you're building the thing.



Most confusion comes from mixing rungs mid-conversation — a business risk explained with a bottom-rung detail, or an engineering call made with a top-rung generalization.



**Knowing which rung you're on is
half the battle.**

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